



Figure 5: Example of a good first issue in Babel (Credit: OSI 2021)

For instance, if you choose to contribute to Babel, a random issue will be automatically picked. To start working on the issue, go to the given GitHub link.



Tip: Before making any contribution, check whether the project has been actively maintained over time so that your contribution request gets accepted soon.

Work on a project: To make a pull request for starting your first contribution, go to the link *aka.ms/first-pr* that will take you to the GitHub repository called 'First Contributions'. There you can access a tutorial on how to create your first pull request, which includes forking the repository, cloning the repository on your local machine, and making a change to a file — for example, adding your user name by creating a new branch, committing the change to a local copy of the project, pushing those changes to GitHub and then creating the actual pull request where the project maintenance will be able to review it, give a feedback and accept/reject your changes.

As stated earlier, coding isn't the only way to contribute to an open source project. There are many other ways. The first one is to promote

the project and share it on different social media platforms. If you have experience with a particular project, then you can answer some of the questions related to it on Stack Overflow or GitHub. It will be very helpful for project maintenance.

Another good way to make the first contribution is to go through the project documentation and fix errors. You can also write tutorials and translate the documentation into different languages, making the project accessible to a lot of different people.

If you come across any bug, then do report it. If you don't do so, nobody's going to have a look and fix it in time. Writing unit tests for projects, especially after witnessing a bug that escaped someone else's notice, is also a good way to contribute to any open source project. And if you are a good designer, then you can design a nice logo for a particular open source project.

Besides the above, there are multiple ways to contribute. You can try to come up with some other helpful ones.



Tip: If you plan to work on an issue for a specific project, do assign yourself to it so that other people can know that someone else is working.

Submit your pull request: Certain things can increase the chances of your pull request getting accepted. The first thing is to read the contribution guidelines before submission. It's good to describe the changes made and why for the project.

Just be mindful that some of the people maintaining an open source project won't be able to regularly check the repository. So be patient and allow them to go through your pull request. If not now, they will do so in a few days.

Giving and receiving feedback is an essential part of the open source cycle. It helps to understand what needs to be changed. If you receive criticism, don't take it as a personal attack but as a means to further improve your skills. Since hundreds of big open source projects get reviewed every day, feedback on your contribution may take days — even months. Nevertheless, don't worry. You will eventually receive it.

Get ready for a new adventure

After all your hard work, unfortunately, everything may not work out the first time. Maybe your contribution didn't fit the project's objective or someone else contributed in a better way. Don't worry, it happens. Remember to never give up. Once your contribution gets accepted, you'll be motivated to contribute even more.

So, if you love the philosophy of sharing content, receiving feedback and being a part of a larger tech ecosystem, then the life of an open source contributor is meant for you. **END** 🐧

The article is based on a talk given by Yohan Lasorsa, senior developer advocate, Microsoft, at Open Source India 2021.

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